

# RIGHT, WRONG, STILL OPEN

*Lee's eight chapters, what each concludes, and how it has lasted. The final column is this edition's, not his.*

| Chapter                              | What he concludes                                                                    | Where it stands                                                               |
|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>The Kraken</b>                    | That the kraken of the Norse accounts is a giant cephalopod.                         | Sustained.                                                                    |
| <b>The Great Sea Serpent</b>         | That the reports are several different things, and he cannot say which is which.     | Still open — except the saurian, which is not sustained.                      |
| <b>The Mermaid</b>                   | That the fish-tailed deity is an artistic convention and the sighting is a sirenian. | Both sustained.                                                               |
| <b>The Lernean Hydra</b>             | That the hydra is an octopus.                                                        | Plausible and unproven; it is an argument about art, and art does not settle. |
| <b>Scylla and Charybdis</b>          | That Scylla is an octopus in a cliff cave.                                           | As above.                                                                     |
| <b>The “Spouting” of Whales</b>      | That the spout is breath condensing, not water from the mouth.                       | Sustained exactly.                                                            |
| <b>The “Sailing” of the Nautilus</b> | That the animal does not sail and the arms are not sails.                            | Sustained, and now known to go further: those arms secrete the shell.         |
| <b>Barnacle Geese</b>                | That the resemblance between a barnacle's cirri and a bird's head began the belief.  | Sustained.                                                                    |

Three places to hold him to account

1. The surviving marine reptile. Lee reports, without endorsing, Gosse's suggestion that a plesiosaur outlived its era and is reported as a sea serpent. There is no fossil record of these animals after the end-Cretaceous extinction and no evidence of a surviving lineage. Figure 24 of the first handbook is a skeleton — which only his List of Illustrations says, and the caption under the plate does not.
2. The fish-gods. The plates that open the mermaid chapter rest on a reading of Dagon and of the Assyrian reliefs that scholarship has abandoned: the name is now referred to dagan, grain, and the fish-cloaked figures are apkallu, sages wearing a fish as a garment. A man in a fish cloak is not a man with a fish's body.
3. The sirenian that lives in the wrong ocean. Manatees and dugongs are tropical animals, and a great many mermaid reports come from Norway, Greenland and the North Atlantic. Seals are the obvious candidate Lee never takes up — although in footnote 41 he prints an engraving from the Roman catacombs and remarks that the creature in it is “apparently not a fish, but a seal”.

*From Sea Monsters Unmasked, and Sea Fables Explained, Valice Classics 14. Free at [valicepress.com/companion/sea-monsters-unmasked](http://valicepress.com/companion/sea-monsters-unmasked)*